

Episode 41: Sorry! Once Again Setting Aside "Colour Direction" for a Bit to Talk About *Hakaba Kitaro*

Once again, it's been two weeks since my last update.

The other day, Tokyo had its "first spring wind." Rather than "blew," "raged" would be the correct expression. The brown wind that stirred up dirt and sand was just like a sandstorm. The entire city was dyed in yellow-brown colours. The Shinjuku high-rise district hazy in the distance beyond the sandstorm felt like Middle Eastern footage or perhaps *Fist of the North Star* (laugh).

And with that "first spring wind" comes this year's "pollen season."

Fortunately, I myself don't have even a speck of hay fever, but my wife has terrible hay fever. Not just her eyes and nose—when pollen gets on her skin, those spots turn red and inflamed, and it's apparently itchy beyond belief.

Hmm...

So currently, our household is doing all laundry indoors (bitter laugh).

While being grateful to my parents for giving birth to me with a body free of allergies, I'm still a little scared this year that I might suddenly develop hay fever (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro, currently airing to great acclaim, has completed production through episode 8 "Kaiki Ichiban Shobu" (Strange Number One Match), which airs this week (in Kanto). We have 4 episodes left to broadcast and 3 episodes left to work on. We've already finished editing and dubbing through the final episode, and now we're rushing to catch up on the screen work, which is running behind as usual.

Essentially, my work as colour designer is mostly finished, and now I'm just going through checks of the rushes as they come up. Plus work on additional cuts for the DVD release and corrections. Oh, and DVD packaging work too. Well, that's for later.

But it really is fast and short, isn't it—11 episodes total. I talked about this with Nagai-san, the colour designer for *Mononoke*, and she said "It's short, 11 episodes. It's over in a flash (laugh)." It feels like just when you finally get used to it and think "Alright, now let's cause another ruckus..." it ends. Hmm, I'd like to do a bit more... such wistful thoughts (bitter laugh).

But well, *Hakaba Kitaro* doesn't have many original stories left, and with this type of work, carelessly creating original episodes can be counterproductive, so it's probably better not to (bitter laugh). So giving our all to these 11 episodes might be just right. With everything, it's good to leave a little regret at the point where you want "just a bit more..." (laugh). So I want to enjoyably finish the rest.

Now, changing topics. The ending that airs each week. The text that appears behind the staff credits—I mentioned before that it "changes every week," but actually, that text is excerpts from next week's episode script.

Hakaba Kitaro is structured so that cuts from the "next episode preview" are inserted into the ending footage using split screen, but by showing not just those preview images but also excerpts from the script itself, the entire ending essentially becomes the "next episode preview."

I'm in charge of deciding the colours for that text (incidentally, the person choosing which phrases to change colour for emphasis is assistant director Goto-kun), and I'm having fun playing with the colour balance, deliberately making it easy to read for some episodes and hard to read for others (laugh). Not just the main story colours—"colour" is interesting in places like this too.

Well, *Hakaba* has just a little left, but I wonder what will happen with the text in the final episode 11's ending? Actually, that hasn't been decided yet...

(08.02.26)